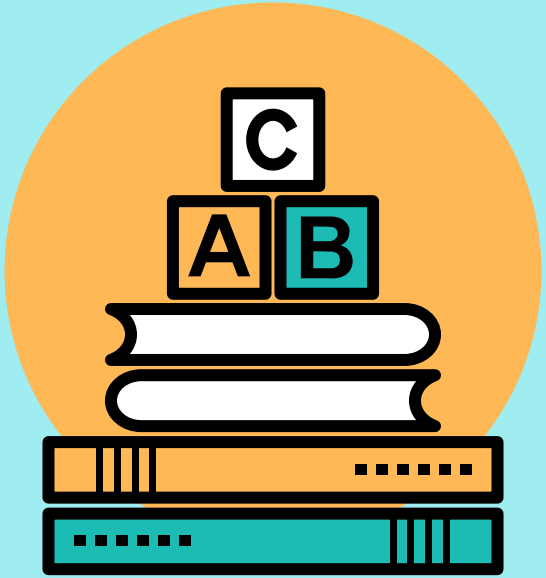
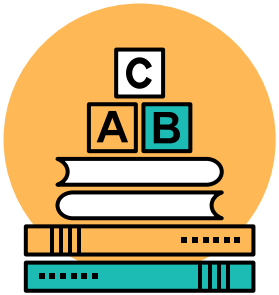


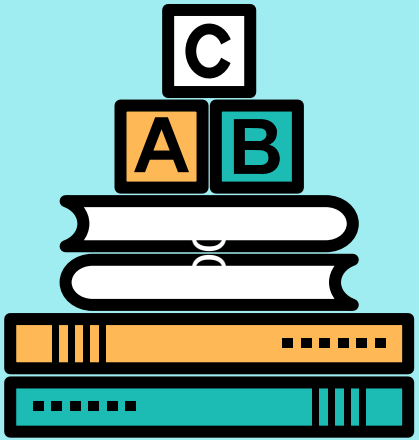
Chapter 1: Ethics: An Overview

Chenda Soviphea

Agenda

A	**Warm-up Activities** Review and Video
B	**Metaphysics and the Study of Human Nature** i.e. Metaphysical Dualism, Buddhism, One-substance Theories…
C	**Epistemology and Moral Knowledge** i.e. Epistemology and The Role of Experience
D	**Philosophy and the Search for Wisdom** i.e. Being autonomous, Self-realization, Skepticism, Plato's Allegory of the Cave





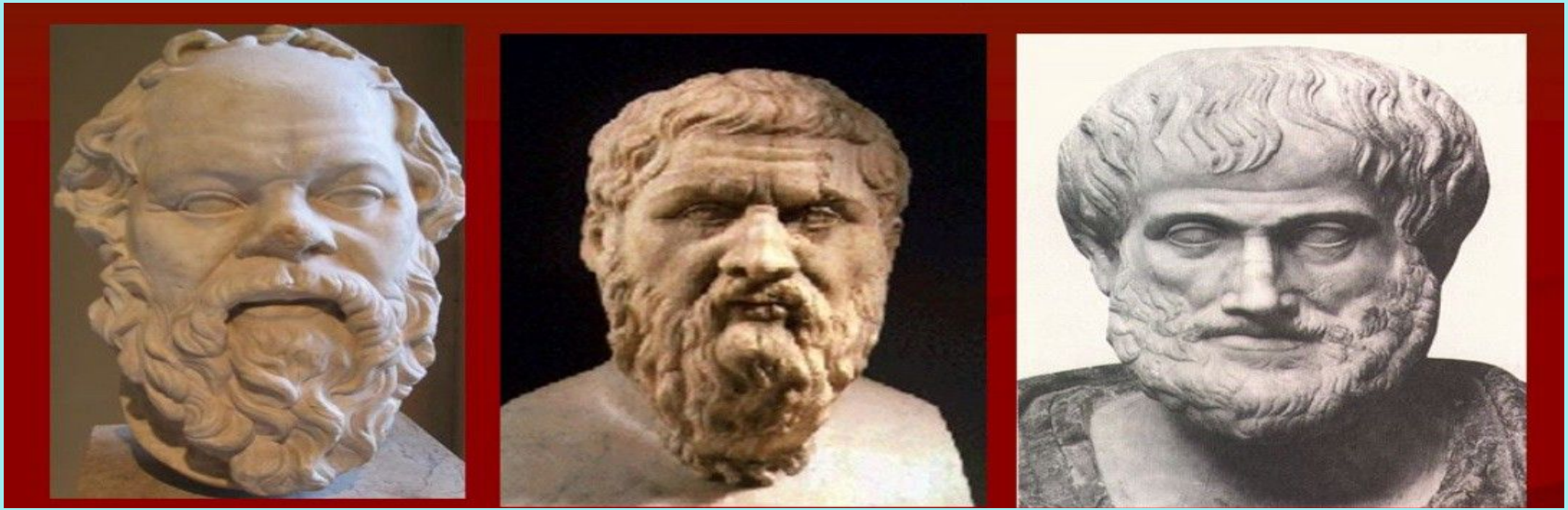
Warm-up Activity

Review (10mn) and Video (15mn)

1. https://forms.gle/25QqtDSwD1CN5uHRA
2. Before the video, if you had to share a house/room, how would you treat your room mate? (5mn in Ms. Meeting Chat)
3. After watching the video, how important is the ethics in daily life?

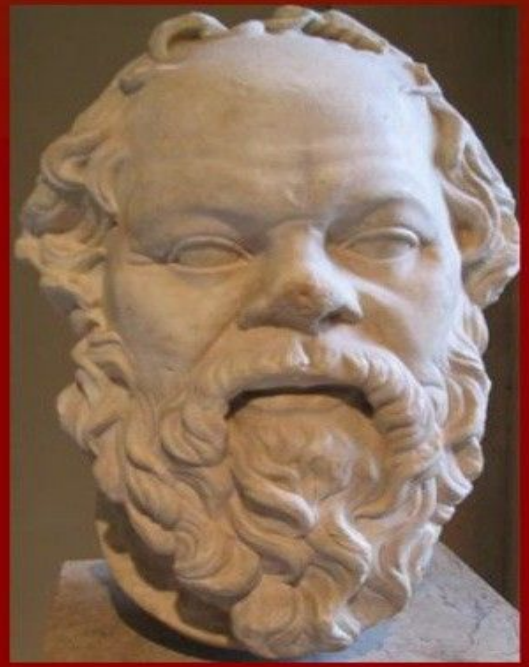
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BP2o_s7YrSA&t=280s

Do You Know Them?

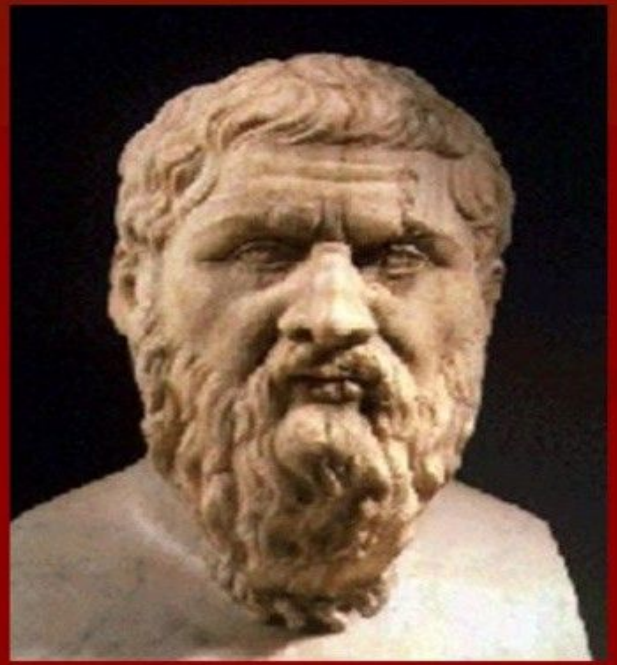


1. Which one is Plato?
2. Which one is Socrates?
3. Which one is Aristotle?

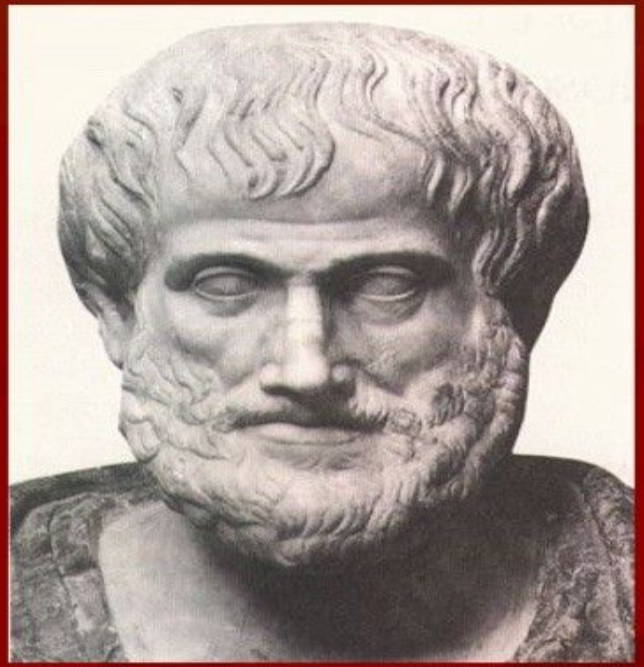
Here Are the Answers!



Socrates



Plato



Aristotle

Ethics an Overview

Mandala

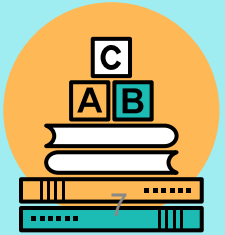
pp. 120-121



3. Write three of your wishes and share with three people.

Mandala: 1. ancient Sanskrit word for a circle that symbolizes the cosmic order (the pattern circle or the practice of writing your wishes until become true).

Moral Community (MC): is made up of all those beings or things that have *moral worth* or *value* in themselves, **according to that theory**.



Pre-reading Question:

Is it okay for moral community to hurt or exploit someone outside the community?

Let's go to the poll!

Pre-reading Question:

1. Stand up and line up!

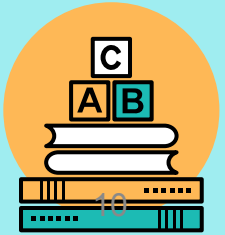
2. Is it okay for moral community to hurt or exploit someone outside the community?

3. Move to the YES or NO.

Moral Community (MC):

- Those within a MC have moral value; they deserve *protection and* to be treated with *respect* and *dignity*.
- Those outside the MC have no moral value – hence are subject to exploitation.
- By definition, it is ***morally acceptable*** to exploit anything outside the MC.

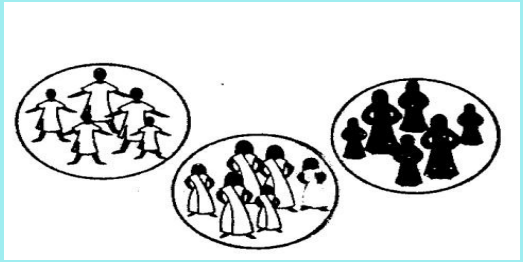
Note various examples of how various theories depict their MC's on pp. 9-10.



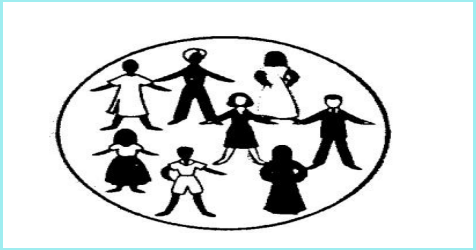
Moral Community (textbook pp. 9-10):



Ethical Subjectivism

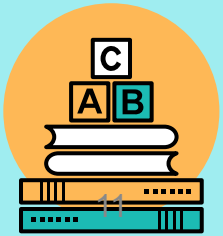


Cultural Relativism

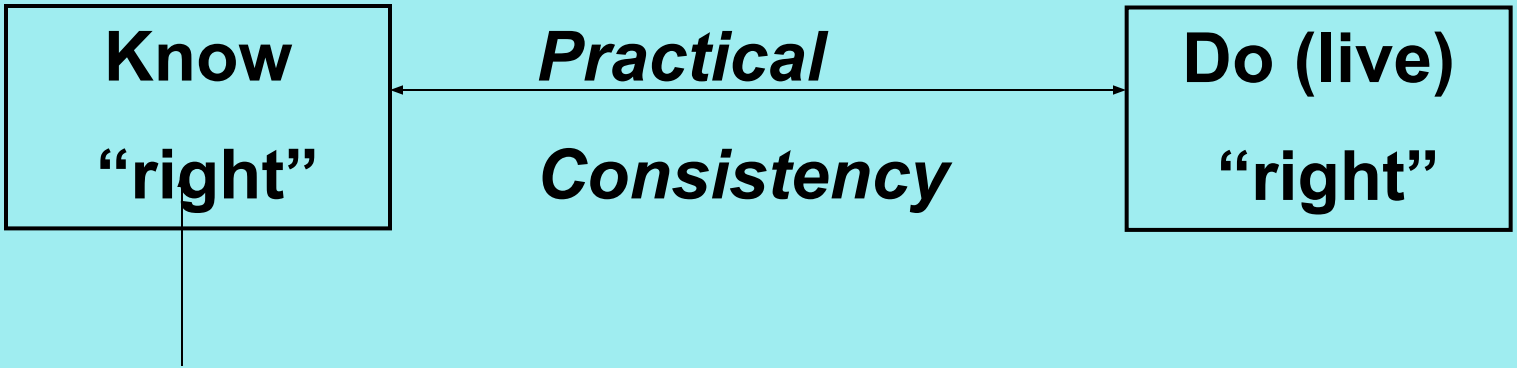


* Universalism

*** Work in a team of three, walk around, and let others guess based on your description and examples!

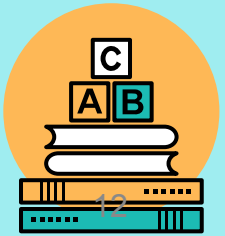


Good life: a life lived *consistent* with a *coherent* set of moral values.



logically consistent

No double standards

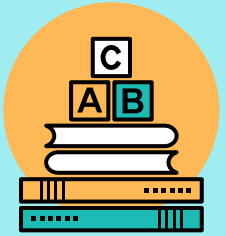




Sample

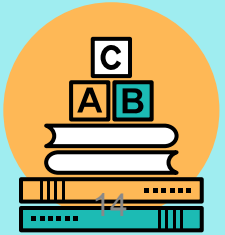
Good life Checklist

1. Work in pair and design a good life checklist with at least 7 items.
2. Tick the items you and your pair have achieved.



Good life:

- Aristotle claimed the pursuit of the good life was our most important activity as humans.
- Others would say that this is the only road to true happiness.
- Ontology, Metaphysics, Epistemology



Ontology – Part of Philosophy

The three areas of Philosophy

Directly influence teaching theory and practice

Metaphysics
(What is real?)

Ontology
Questions about existence and being

Cosmology
Nature and origin of the universe

Epistemology
(How do we know?)

Knowing Through
Experience – Reason
Authority – Intuition
Active Construction

Axiology
(What is right?)

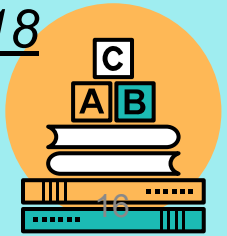
Ethics
Aesthetics

Ontology = Questions about Existence and Being

Metaphysics and the Study of Human Nature:

Metaphysics: is the branch of philosophy concerned with the **study of the nature of *reality***, including what it means to be human.

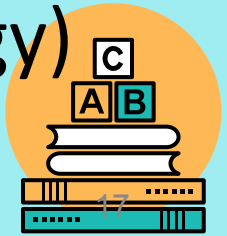
Extra Video: https://edpuzzle.com/media/5f4033d43f75c03efe80ac18
Scanning Time (15mn): pp 12-17



Metaphysics and the Study of Human Nature:

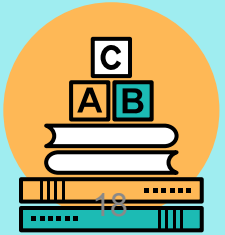
Views on ethics depend on our beliefs regarding these three issues:

1. Role of human beings in the universe
2. Existence of free will (or determinism)
3. Nature & origin of knowledge (Epistemology)



Attempts to answer: Padlet's Time!

- *Are humans different from other animals?*
  - *If so how?*
- *What does that suggest about morality?*



Metaphysics : the study of reality

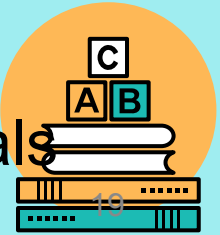
Physical

Body

CAUSAL LAWS

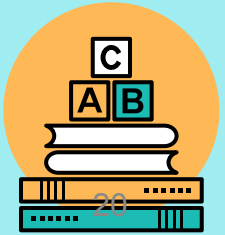
Non-Physical
Rational Mind
Soul / Spirit

A ***metaphysical dualist*** recognizes both realities but emphasizes the rational mind – separates us from animals



Metaphysical Dualism

- The body is subject to CAUSAL laws (ie. those of biology, physics, chemistry).
- The Mind is invisible and rational.
- Rational mind contains our conscience and the abilities to reason, wonder and ask questions, make informed decisions and to control our emotions.

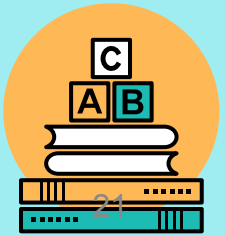


Anthropocentrism (moral phil.)**:**

The belief that since only **adult humans* have a rational mind**, they are the central or most significant reality of the universe, and hence are morally superior.

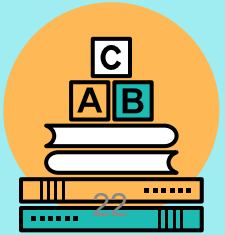
– Is a very hierarchical view of reality

- Later we will see that Aristotle (p. 172) believed that *women were not rational – unwarranted assumption*



Anthropocentrism (moral phil.)**:**

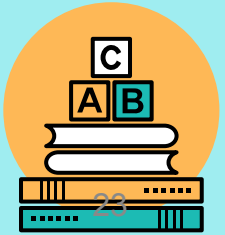
- Humans express their distinction (vs. animals) through their use of reason (non-material) which allows us to seek the truth and achieve the good life.



Anthropocentrism:

- Assumes **LOGIC OF DOMINATION** which says:

*Where a difference exists, **one must necessarily dominate** (be superior to) the other.*

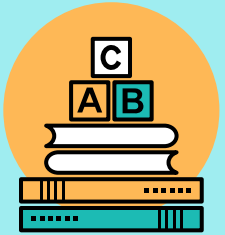


Should males dominate females?

Or

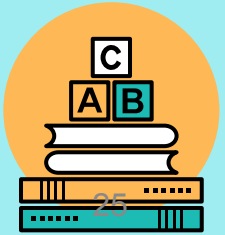
Should females dominate males?

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VBP0-XUe6bU



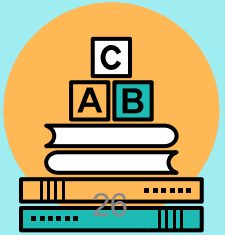
Critical of anthropocentrism and of male's domination of philosophy**,**

Eco-feminism – rejects anthropocentrists' **logic of domination** and describes man's domination of women and the environment as one issue.



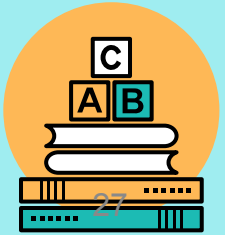
Eco-feminists maintain that males:

- by establishing a difference between humans and the enviro as well as between males and females, men have made the hasty and false assumption that *one must necessarily* be morally superior;



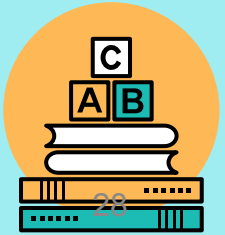
Eco-feminists maintain that males:

- hence giving males dominance over both the enviro and women.
- Eco-feminists recognize a difference between men and women but **reject** the assumption that one must *necessarily* dominate the other.



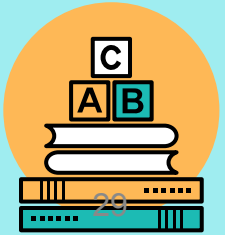
Eco-feminists see that domination leads only to disaster.

- They note how humanity's domination over the environment has not only led to the destruction of the environment (the dominated), but how it also threatens humanity (the dominator).



Eco-feminists see that domination leads only to disaster.

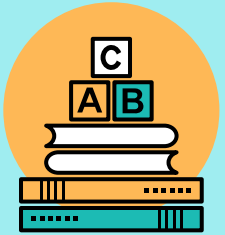
- They explain that man's domination of women will only lead to a similar disaster.
- As such, while they recognize a biological difference between the sexes, Eco-feminist prescribe equality as being in the best interests of both sexes.
- *https://create.kahoot.it/details/fce927c0-5d11-4b35-943c-c53d9f7f852e*



Week 3
Pre-lesson Question:

Which one of the principles of Buddhism became popular?

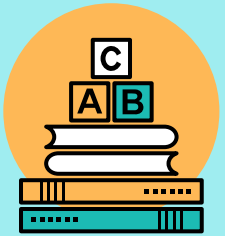
A. Buddha was a wise person.
B. Buddha was an attractive person
C. Buddhism did not accept the caste system.
D. Buddhism was only for smart people.



Week 3
Pre-lesson Question:

What one of the principles of Buddhism became popular?

A. Buddha was a wise person.
B. Buddha was an attractive person
C. Buddhism did not accept the caste system.
D. Buddhism was only for smart people.



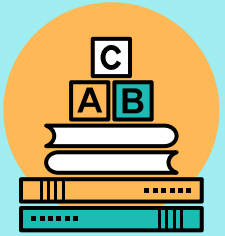
Review from Last Week

1. What is the synonym of physical body?
   A. M _ _ _ _ _ _ _ (8 syllables)

2. What are the synonyms of nonmaterial mind?
   A. I _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ _ (10 syllables) C. S _ _ _ (4 syllables)
   B. S _ _ _ _ _ (6 syllables)

3. Which supports the logic of domination?
   B. Dualism *C. Anthropocentrism*
   C. Eco feminism

4. Which supports women, nature, and equality?
   D. Moral community *C. Universalism*
   E. Eco feminism



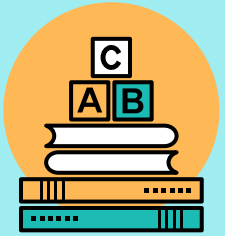
Review from Last Week

1. What is the synonym of physical body?
   - *A. Material (8 syllables)*

2. What are the synonyms of nonmaterial mind?
   - *A. Immaterial (10 syllables)*
   - *B. Spirit (6 syllables)*
   - *C. Soul (4 syllables)*

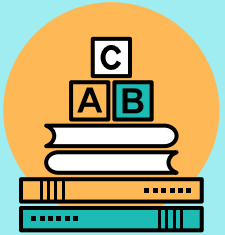
3. Which supports the logic of domination?
   - *B. Dualism*
   - *C. Eco feminism*
   - *C. Anthropocentrism*

4. Which supports women, nature, and equality?
   - *D. Moral community*
   - *E. Eco feminism*
   - *C. Universalism*



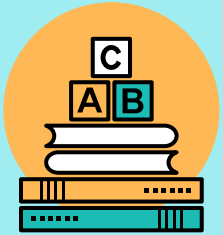
Have many have you experienced these?

1. Blaming you: They may blame you for everything, even if it's their mistake.
2. Family/Isolation: They may intentionally isolate you from your social circle. The more isolated you feel, the more you may become dependent on them.
3. Jealousy: They may have extreme jealousy and possessiveness. Jealousy and possessiveness are a common early warning sign of abuse.
4. Gaslighting/manipulation: They may lie to you, intentionally set you up to fail, undermine you, manipulate you, and convince you that you are the problem.
5. Criticizing your friends: They may limit your exposure to friends.
6. Intimidation: They may always try to make the decisions, and want to control everything, from what you wear to where you go.
7. A constant need to defend yourself
8. They are always criticizing you//They are demanding.
9. They are dramatized.
10. They keep score.



Here are some signs that someone may be trying to dominate you:

1. Blaming you: They may blame you for everything, even if it's their mistake.
2. Family/Isolation: They may intentionally isolate you from your social circle. The more isolated you feel, the more you may become dependent on them.
3. Jealousy: They may have extreme jealousy and possessiveness. Jealousy and possessiveness are a common early warning sign of abuse.
4. Gaslighting/manipulation: They may lie to you, intentionally set you up to fail, undermine you, manipulate you, and convince you that you are the problem.
5. Criticizing your friends: They may limit your exposure to friends.
6. Intimidation: They may always try to make the decisions, and want to control everything, from what you wear to where you go.
7. A constant need to defend yourself
8. They are always criticizing you//They are demanding.
9. They are dramatized.
10. They keep score



One-substance theories: Buddhism

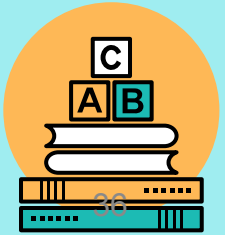
Physical & Non-Physical Are "One"

Mind & Body are one substance, in fact

All living beings and non-living things are "One".

Unity of *all reality.*

- Dynamic web of interactions that condition or influence (but not determine) our actions.

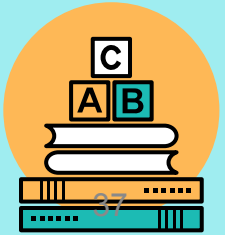


Buddhism

Simple lifestyle: a life lived respectful of and in harmony with other humans and nature

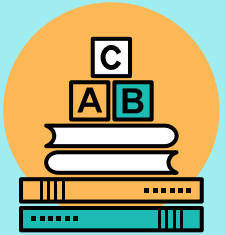
- Respect for all living beings and not taking more than you need.
- Approach shared by some African tribes as well as Indigenous Native American tribes.

- Read pp. 14-15 re: Buddhism & Human Rights



Buddhism Extra Information:

https://wayground.com/admin/quiz/621c37bcdf53b4001de6d291?at=69b151f5d872f299d7f4323a



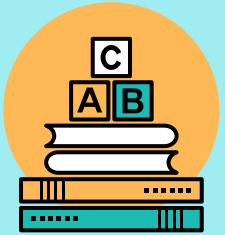
1. Please go to page 15 (10mn) & read One-substance Theories.
2. What is the main focus in One-substance Theories?

A. Rational mind?

B. Physical body?

C. Both?

D. None?



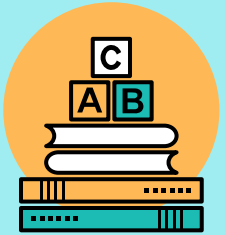
1. Please go to page 15 (10mn) and read One-substance Theory.
2. What is the main focus in One-substance Theory?

A. Rational mind?

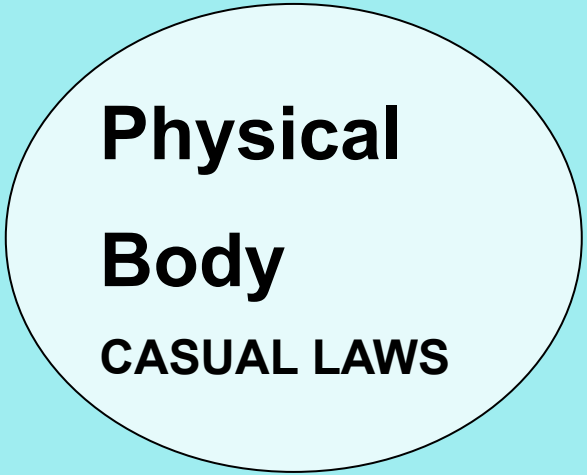
B. Physical body?

C. Both?

D. None?

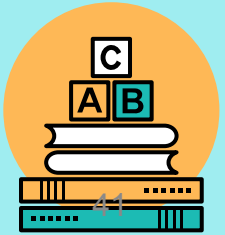


Western One Substance Theory
Metaphysical Materialism



A **metaphysical materialist recognizes only the physical body as *real*.**

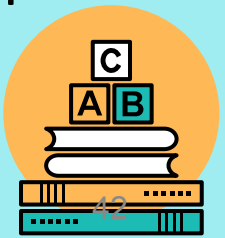
Concepts such as the mind & soul are abstract – they are rejected as irrelevant. All things (incl. morality) can only be explained in terms of physical matter.



Western One Substance Theory

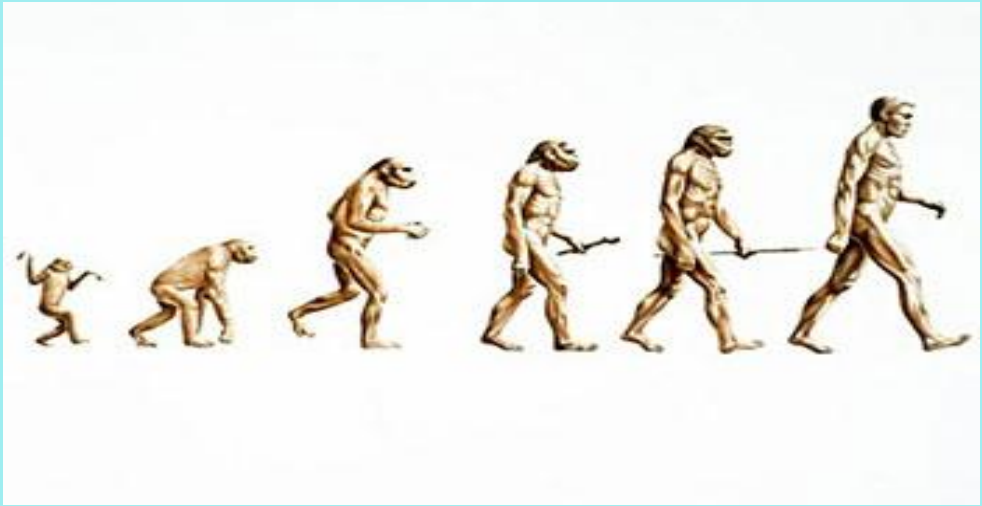
Metaphysical materialists are scientists that adhere to *logical empiricism* (epistemological theory) that says that all knowledge is based on scientific observation of the physical world.

- Hence, if things are not *observable, repeatable* and *predictable* then nothing can be known of such things.
- The mind is not observable (it is non-physical) and human behaviour which may be a proxy for our thinking in not – repeatable or predictable.



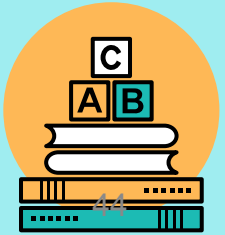
One-substance theories:

- **Sociobiology:** assumes MM and applies evolutionary theory (Darwin, p. 113) to social sciences.



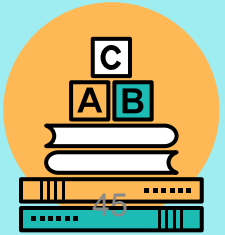
One-substance theories:

- Morality is based on biological (natural) requirements and drives – the same innate instincts and urges as other animals;
- What is morally good is what has allowed the human species (*homo sapiens*) to survive.



One-substance theories:

- What has allowed our species (and all others) to survive is our ability to:
- Make babies – protect them *Selfishness*
- Come to the aid of the species when threatened by other species *Self<u>less</u>ness*



One-substance theories:

- **Biological altruism** (selflessness) is the innate sense of cooperative behaviour especially

with those that share our genes – in spite of our biological tendencies to be selfish (egoism).

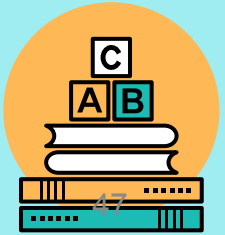
- Due to this irresolvable contradiction

(selfishness vs. selflessness) metaphysical materialism is **rejected** by most philosophers as a basis for morality.



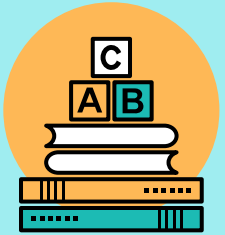
Views on ethics depend on our beliefs regarding these three issues:

1. Role of human beings in the universe
2. Existence of free will (or determinism)
3. Nature & origin of knowledge (Epistemology)



Let’s Watch This!

https://edpuzzle.com/media/62015607f793a742d61a5c85



To what extent are humans in control of their current behaviour?

Completely

in control

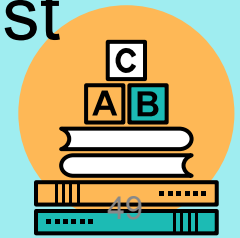
Existentialist

(Freewill)

Not at all

in control

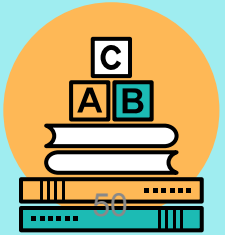
Determinist



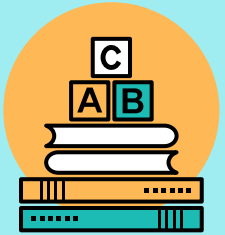
Existence of Free Will (or Determinism):

Determinism: argues that all events incl. our behaviour, are governed by causal laws (science) – like all physical things and beings..

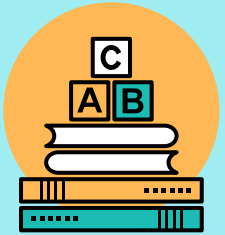
- Free will does not exist.
- *"My behaviour today is determined by past events in my life, therefore I have little control over / responsibility for my own behaviour."*
- An attempt to describe human behaviour in purely scientific terms.
- Emphasizes the physical.



1. Work in four big groups!
2. Read on page Determinism Vs Free Will and Determinism and Excuses from pages 16-18! (5mn)
3. Write 6 True/False statements in a blank paper (5mn).
4. Ask another group to try your statements!

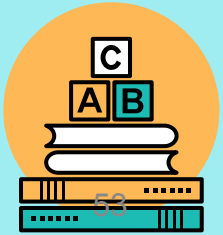


1. Work in two big groups!
2. Read on page Determinism Vs Free Will and Determinism and Excuses from pages 16-18! (10mn)
3. Write 6 True/False statements in Google Form (10mn) and add sovipheachenda91@gmail.com as a collaborator.
4. Ask another group to try your statements!



Determinism:

- Put simply, a determinist believes that our behaviour today is pre-determined by past events in our (current) lives
- we are like pre-programmed computers acting out a pre-determined script.



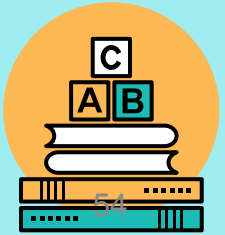
Determinism:

- **Sigmund Freud** – (Psychoanalyst, 1856-1939)

claimed that:

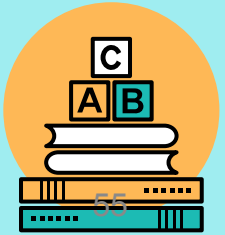
- Humans are governed by powerful unconscious forces
- Behaviour is determined by instinct and past

events in our lives, esp. childhood and relationship with our mother and father.



Determinism:

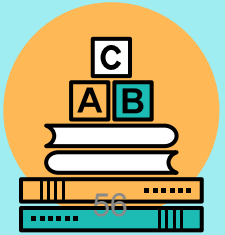
- **BF Skinner** (Amer psychologist / Behavioralist (1904-90)
- Discovered that similar to animals, proper human behaviour, if rewarded, would be repeated in the future **(Operant Conditioning)**
- Behaviour is based on past conditioning



Existence of Free Will (or Determinism):

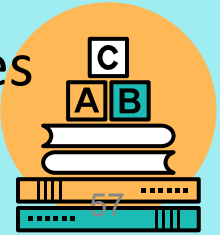
Existentialists: argue that as *rational beings,* humans are defined only by our freedom to *choose*, incl. choosing to control ourselves (or not).

- Each person has the responsibility to create their own self including selecting the moral principles upon which we act.
- Each person can and must be held accountable for their choices and actions.
- Emphasizes the non-physical, rational mind.



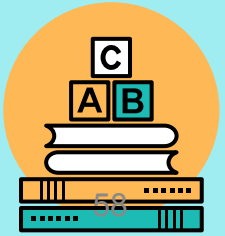
Existence of Free Will (or Determinism):

- **Anthropocentrism** is the moral philosophy arising from a metaphysical dualist perspective on reality. Anthropocentrism holds that humans derive their moral value from the rational mind (versus other animals).
- To an **existentialist**, humans demonstrate their human nature by exercising their rational mind – i.e. controlling their own behaviour.
- To an **existentialist**, the more one is able to control their own behaviour (in spite of emotional temptations), one demonstrates their rational ability, which in turn demonstrates their human nature and finally their moral value.



Existence of Free Will (or Determinism):

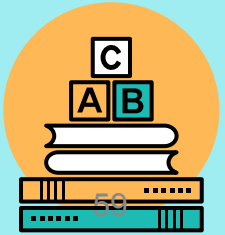
- **Buddhism:** acknowledges that we are *influenced* by things beyond our control but **disagrees** with determinism.
- Buddhism holds that we can be truly free by rising above circumstances and practicing detachment:
  - We need to let go of the illusion of the self (since in reality there is no self [atman])
  - With detachment comes nirvana and true wisdom.



Existence of Free Will (or Determinism):

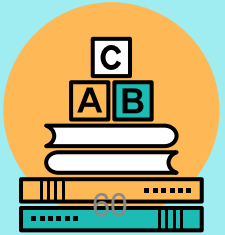
Debate: to what extent can we hold people morally responsible for their actions?

- Legal cases in the US suggest a scientific trend towards seeing forces beyond one's control as being responsible for our moral shortcomings.
- A trend of re-labeling behaviour such as alcoholism and pedophilia as *mental illnesses* or *disabilities* rather than *moral weaknesses* – *The Abuse Excuse.*



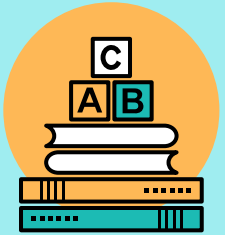
– *Opinion is that exercise of the human will which helps us make a decision without information.*

- Erskine (1943)



Self-test: Do you believe in Determinism or Free Will?

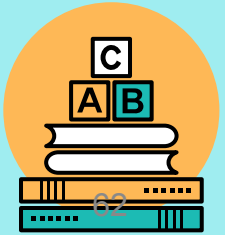
https://psycho-tests.com/test/free-will-vs-determinism



Existence of Free Will (or Determinism):

Views on ethics depend on our beliefs regarding these three issues:

1. Role of human beings in the universe
2. Existence of free will (or determinism)
3. Nature & origin of knowledge (Epistemology)

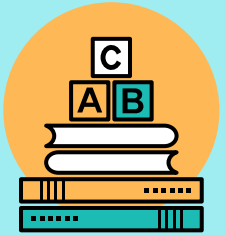


Survey Time (5mn)

What are your ways of getting knowledge? You can choose more than ONE answer.

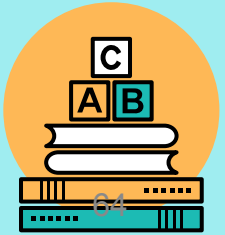
1. Be Curious
2. Reading
3. Research
4. Listening
5. Writing
6. Teach Others
7. Practice
8. Be Thirsty and Willing
9. Be Mindful and Open
10. Observe
11. Reason
12. Experiment
13. Self-analysis and Discipline
14. Learn from Failures
15. Creative Sparks

https://forms.gle/jiry6J4jYQ4nRmcK9



Epistemology: the part of philosophy that is concern with the *study of knowledge* incl. moral knowledge.

- It addresses questions about the nature (incl. origin of) and limits of knowledge and how it can be **validated** (cross-checked).
- Attempts to answer the question: *"How do I know what I know?"*



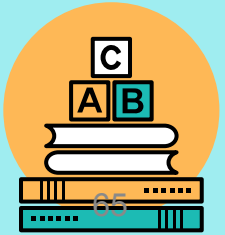
Epistemology & Moral Knowledge:

- Reason, intuition and experience (incl. 5 senses) are possible ways of knowing
- however most Western philosophers see **reason** as the primary source of moral knowledge.

Reason - Rationalism: Philosophy

Intuition - Moral Minimalism: Religion

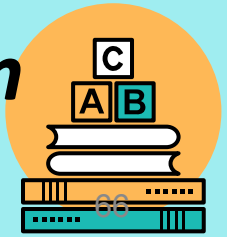
Experience - Empiricism: Science



Reason (v) – "the power of understanding the connection between the general and the particular"

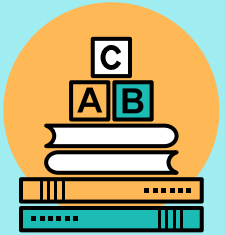
Rationalism – epistemological theory that *most* human knowledge comes through reason rather than through physical senses.

Do not confuse ***rationalism*** and ***rationalization***



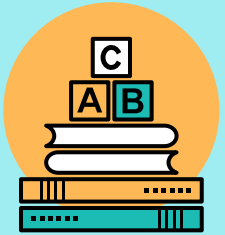
Scenario

You and other classmates wanted to have a trip to Siem Reap altogether after year 4 final exam, but your parents rejected completely. Write the examples of rationalism (logical reasons) and rationalization (the act of wanting to win) to respond to them to let you go.



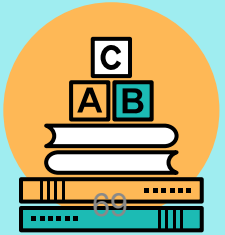
Video Time:

1. What is epistemology? https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hwU8o5fS2-s&t=181s



Intuition – immediate or self-evident knowledge that does not require proof.

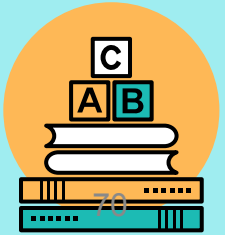
- *Utilitarian* – pain is a moral evil;
- *Confucians* – benevolence (kindness/good will) is good;
- *Rights ethicists* – all people are created equal.



Intuition:

Moral minimalists – believe that there are certain minimal moral requirements that we "know" through intuition.

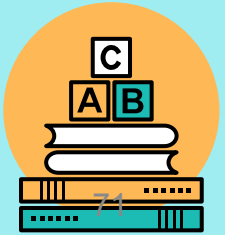
- Torturing children is bad.
- Murdering innocent, helpless people is bad.



Intuition:

Problems with using intuition as the only source of morals:

- Not all such “truths” are self-evident to everyone
- We know something is right but cannot explain the reasons why it is right – so can’t convince others

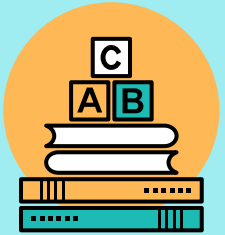


The **Midnight Death:**

1. Work in four big groups.

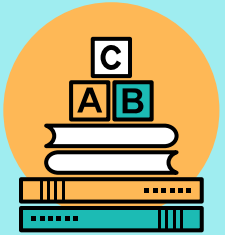
2. What is your final decision?

https://icebreakerideas.com/moral-dilemma-questions/



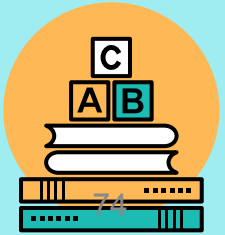
Vocabulary Time:

https://quizlet.com/677256635/test?answerTermSides=4&promptTermSides=6&questionCount=15&questionTypes=14&showImages=true



Experience – even Aristotle that emphasized reason as a source of moral knowledge acknowledges that experience is required for knowledge.

Empiricism: most if not all human knowledge comes through the 5 senses

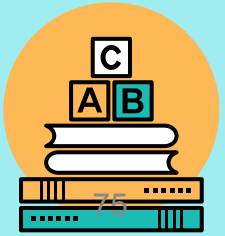


Epistemology & Moral Knowledge:

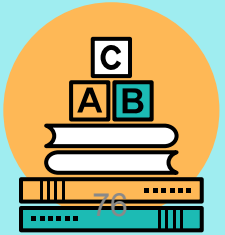
Positivism: attempts to justify all things (incl the study of philosophy) by aligning it with science.

Logical Empiricism: All knowledge is based on scientific observation of the physical world. Moral statements say nothing about the physical world and are therefore not significant.

Positivists believe that since moral judgments cannot be tested in the physical world, they are simply expressions of individual emotions (*emotivists)*.

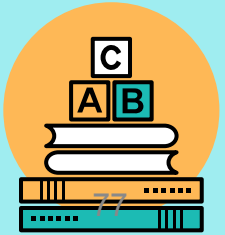


- **Emotivism was *never* widely accepted as a moral theory.**
- **Post WWII even emotivists felt an obligation to call the horrors of the suffering during the Holocaust (war) – morally wrong.**



In summary:

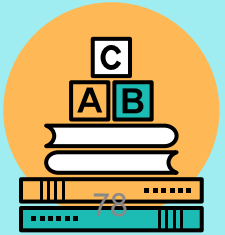
Concept:	**The belief that:**
Rationalism	Most knowledge comes from **reason**.
Empiricism	Most knowledge comes from **experience** – through the 5 senses.
Logical empiricism	**All** knowledge is based on **experience** as observed by scientists.
Moral minimalism	



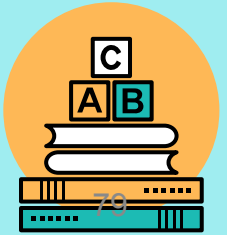
Philosophy and the Search for Wisdom:

Philosophy: *philos* = "lover", *sophos* = "wisdom" – interaction between loving wisdom and taking action/behaving with wisdom.

- *The systematic and critical search for truth & meaning in our lives.*

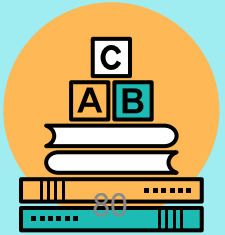


- **Attitude & Action**. Ethics education goes beyond theory by challenging each of us to live consistently with our moral values.
- Philosophy comes from a natural sense of wonder and a basic human need to find higher meaning and value in our lives.
- Children – endless questions.

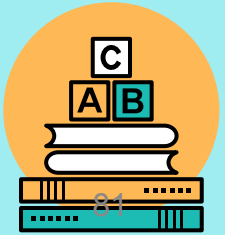


Philosophy and the Search for Wisdom:

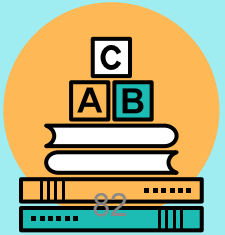
- **Wisdom** begins with self-knowledge which cannot be achieved without self-honesty.
- Wisdom assumes good ends (behaviour) and the search for values.
- Critically examine and analyze our reasons for holding particular views.
- Ch. 11 on Virtue ethics explores different concepts of wisdom.



- **Autonomous** – *auto*= "self"; *nomos* = "law".
- An **autonomous moral agent** is an independent, self governing thinker seeking objective truth about morality.
- Critically examine and analyze our reason for holding particular views.

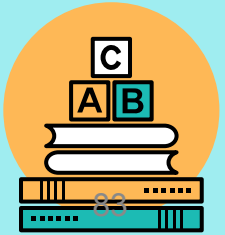


- An **autonomous moral agent** is is very different from the selfish ethical Subjectivism.
- Moral community may vary, but it extends well past the self.

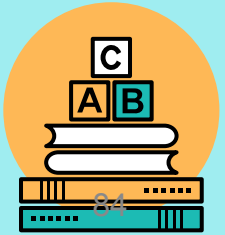


- **Heteronomous moral agent** (hetero = “others”)

is a person who uncritically accepts answers and laws imposed by others.



- **Socratic questioning:** two-way dialogue using questions and answers which provoked people to examine social customs and laws in a search for truth and wisdom.
- The Buddha employed the same strategy (before Socrates was born).

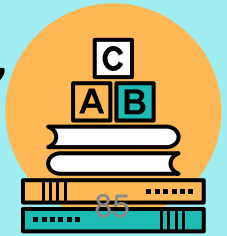


Self-realization: a term used by some philosophers = **self-actualization** (Maslow) = **enlightenment** (Buddha).

- Ask selves:

  "What kind of person do I want to be?" and

  "What do I have to do to achieve this goal?"

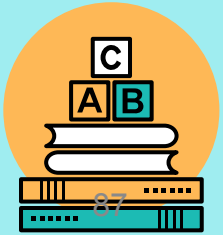




Maslow's hierarchy of needs

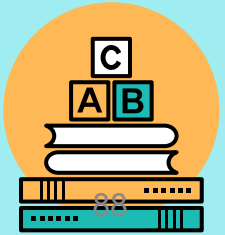
Task:

1. How many levels of needs have you achieved?
2. Self-actualization: *What kind of person do I want to b*e in the next 10 years?



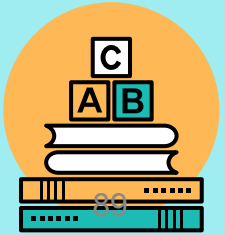
Self-realized/actualized people:

- are **autonomous,** they don't depend on others to decide what to do or believe –
- devote their lives to the search for ultimate values.
- have the courage to be honest with themselves and work hard at being the best at what ever they do.
- don't blame others for their unhappiness and
- don't simply give into "the temptations of the easy way"



Self-realized/Actualized People:

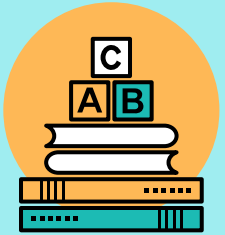
- are critical thinkers, flexible,
- welcome having their views challenged by others,
- open to new ways of seeing the world,
- willing to change their views if necessary and
- **are resistant to cultural conditioning.**



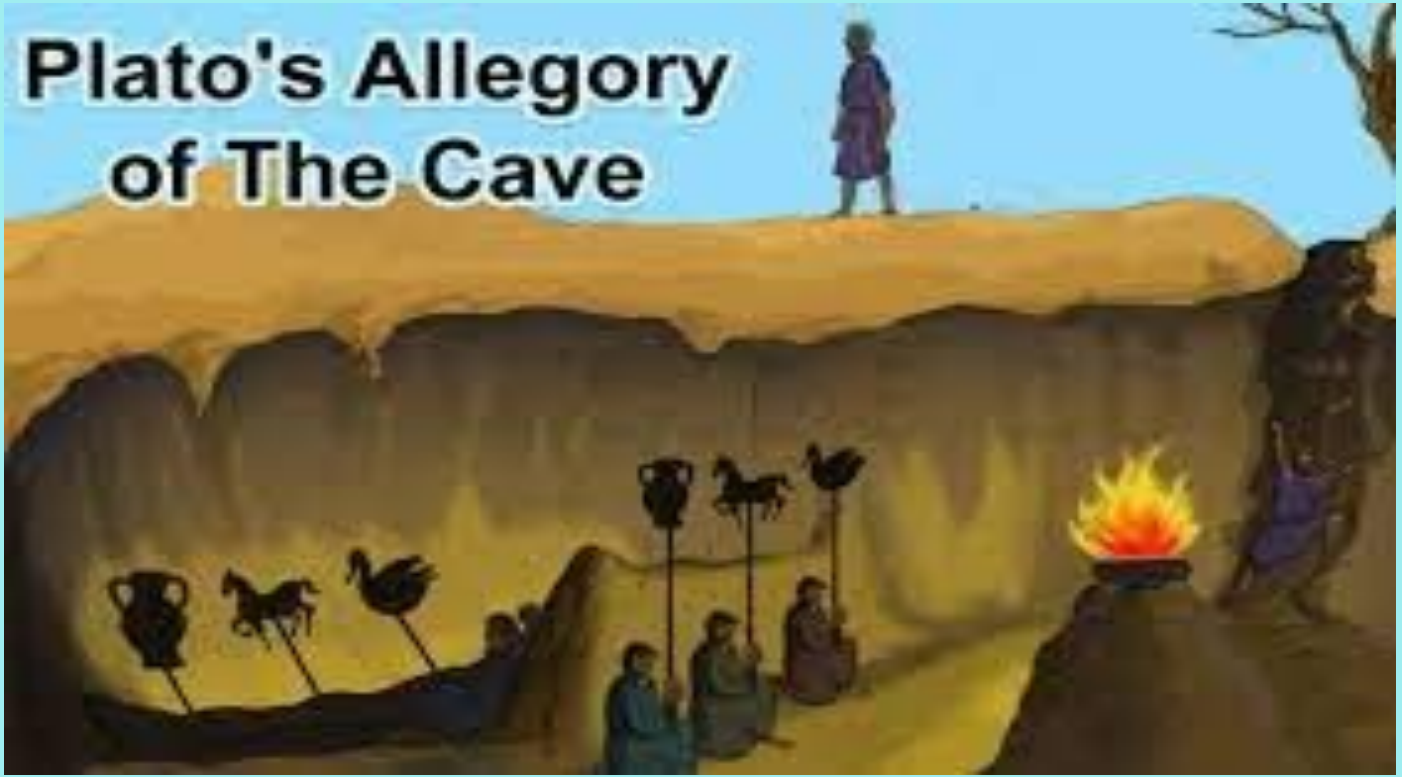
Skepticism Vs Cynicism

Skepticism, unlike cynicism, is grounded in wonder. The skeptic is *always curious and open-minded*, with an eye to the truth.

Cynicism is *closed minded and mocks the possibility of truth*; it begins and ends in doubt. Cynicism denies rather than analyzes. In this sense, cynicism is a means of resisting philosophical thought because it hinders analysis.



Plato’s Allegory Cave



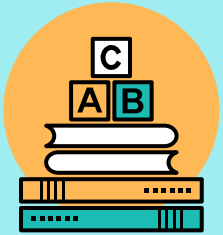
Plato’s Allegory Cave

The budding philosopher has three options:
(1) He can leave the cave again and return to the light. In this case, his newfound wisdom will become irrelevant to the world of human experience.

(2) He can give up the wisdom he has acquired and return to his old beliefs. By doing so, he gives in to public opinion rather than risk being unpopular.

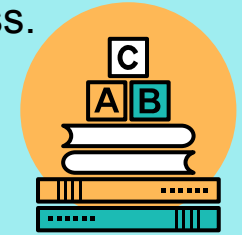
(3) he can remain in the cave and persist in his quest to share his wisdom with others.

Which one would you choose?
== > This last option, according to Plato, is the path of the true philosopher.



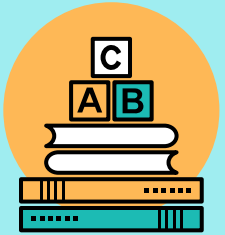
Plato’s Allegory Cave (SIMPLIFIED)

1) He can leave the cave again and return to the light.
In real life, this is like someone who gains deep knowledge—perhaps a researcher, scholar, or critical thinker—but chooses to stay isolated from society. For example, a university professor may discover important truths about social issues but decides not to share them with the public, making their knowledge less useful in everyday life.
(2) He can give up the wisdom he has acquired and return to his old beliefs.
This is like a person who learns new ideas but abandons them to fit in with others. For instance, someone who understands the importance of environmental protection might ignore it because their friends or community do not care, choosing popularity over truth.
(3) He can remain in the cave and persist in his quest to share his wisdom with others.
In real life, this is like a teacher, activist, or leader who continues to educate others despite resistance. For example, a teacher who encourages students to think critically—even when students resist or society disagrees—keeps trying to spread knowledge and awareness.



Homework:

https://www.proprofs.com/quiz-school/story.php?title=epistemology-and-you



~~Agenda~~

A	**~~Warm-up Activities~~** Review and Video
B	**~~Metaphysics and the Study of Human Nature~~** i.e. Metaphysical Dualism, Buddhism, One-substance Theories…
C	**~~Epistemology and Moral Knowledge~~** i.e. Epistemology and The Role of Experience
D	**~~Philosophy and the Search for Wisdom~~** i.e. Being autonomous, Self-realization, Skepticism, Plato's Allegory of the Cave

